

Nayak Jay Prakash (LNJP), Dakshinpuri and Nanglamachi areas of Delhi, the movement is slowly gathering momentum. The project works with young people in slum areas and working class neighbourhoods. It enables innovative use of computers and digital technology while remaining alert to the imperatives of social and cultural specificity and autonomy.

Started in May 2001, the project has enabled youngsters in the age group of 15 to 21 to come together and reflect on and write about everyday life as they experience it. These youngsters, or "Media Practitioners," as Prabhat, an Ankur representative, addresses them, meet regularly in self-regulated spaces called "Compughars" or Mohalla Media Labs. "We encourage young adults to come and spend their time in these labs and acquire different computer and technology-related skills," says Prabhat.

When they started off, these media practitioners were neither proficient in English nor did they have any computer-handling experience. Today, a year later, they are trained in basic computing and multimedia techniques, using the free GNU Linux.

A year later, the kids are trained in basic computing and multimedia techniques using the free GNU Linux



The Wheels That Turn The Clock

A typical Cybermohalla Compughar machine

Intel Celeron 1.1 GHz
128 MB RAM
40 GB HDD
Onboard Intel 810 graphics card
Onboard Intel 801 audio card
Realtek 10/100 network card
PS/2 keyboard
Optical mouse
15" colour monitor

Applications used on the machines

CD burning: k3b
Word processing: Open Office
Desktop publishing: Scribus
Email: KMail/Thunderbird
Graphics: GIMP, Inkscape, Blender
Audio playback: XMMS, AmaroK, JuK
Audio editing: Audacity, Ardour
Video playback: mPlayer, Xing
Video editing: Cinelerra, KdEnlive, Kino, JahShaka
Instant messaging: GAIM, Yahoo! Messenger, Xchat
Web browsing: Mozilla, Firefox, Konqueror, Opera
Web editing: Mozilla Composer, NVU
Games: Tuxracer, Chromium, Lbreakout2, XBill, GnuChess (Xboard)

Tools at work

Students at the media lab use tools such as computers, dictaphones, cameras, pens and notebooks, with which they conduct interviews, record sounds of the *basti*, take photographs and transfer their world as words and images onto the computer. They come together to reflect upon their lives and to share their realities with each other.

The Cybermohalla diaries takes several forms including written text, images and audio fragments. There are several derivatives of the project:

The "Compughar Diaries" is a form of expression for students, and is maintained by everyone. These diaries are the starting points that help generate concepts to create a presentation, a movie or even a documentary. Sound archives include sound bytes from the city, interviews, readings from the diaries and more, while the image archives comprises photographs of the *basti*, their own city and even other cities.

Going techno-savvy, there are hyperlink diaries that are the conversion of the Compughar's flow of concepts and observations through hyperlinked notes, web-enabled through www.sarai.net.

There are also animations that are included in the projects, which are done using GNU Image Manipulation Programs (GIMP). Publications made at the Compughar include wall magazines called "Ibarat," produced every two months and displayed at over 20 places in the *basti*.

Youngsters associated with the project have acquired considerable skill in handling computers, digital cameras, audio

recorders and scanners, and have created short animated movies and basic HTML projects using free software applications. Their writings, photographs, sound recordings and animations have been published as a Compughar book, a compilation of ten booklets, five postcards and a CD.

The People

Representatives from Ankur and Sarai were reluctant to take credit for their work. "At Sarai, we are constantly looking at ways to help eliminate creative inequality in our society.

When Ankur approached us with the Cybermohalla project, we thought it was a good way of reaching out to the non-elite, albeit important, spaces within our society," says Jeebesh Bhagchi of Sarai.

Today, there are about 60 people involved in the various projects of Cybermohalla. "Initially, what started off as a pilot project has now extended to many localities within Delhi. Peer-to-peer networking with sustained efforts from our end has resulted in the success of Cybermohalla," says Prabhat from Ankur.

The Media Practitioners here are an interesting group. Seventeen-year-old Luv Anand from the Dakshinpuri lab is here because he was initially a part of Ankur's "Balclub" project.

A student of Class XII, Luv was introduced to Cybermohalla by Vikram, another media practitioner. "I like media lab because it helps me experiment with text, images and sound. We try to see what others cannot in the regular occurrences like fights at the *mohalla* and present them in a creative way using computers."

Photographs: Mery Xavier



Action at the Dakshinpuri Media Lab